
Breath as Regulation

Companion Workbook — build the breath practice
that retrains your nervous system

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Continuity Member Edition — Month 2 Workbook

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Introduction

A PRINTABLE COMPANION TO THE MONTH 2 MODULE. Build the breath practice that retrains your nervous system.

CHAPTER 1

How to use this workbook

PRINT IT. PUT IT NEAR WHERE YOU'LL DO THE 5-minute daily practice — bedside table, coffee maker, desk.

This is a habit-building workbook. The breath practice itself takes 5 minutes. The workbook keeps you honest about whether you're actually doing it.

Bring it to your next session.

CHAPTER 2

Where You Are Today — Breath Pattern Self-Assessment

TEST 1 — SITTING WATCH: SIT NORMALLY.

Watch yourself breathe for 30 seconds without changing anything. What moves?

- ☐ Shoulders rising and falling (shoulder breathing)
- ☐ Upper chest expanding (chest breathing)
- ☐ Belly rising and falling (diaphragmatic breathing)
- ☐ Belly + chest both moving (mixed)

Test 2 — Lying watch: Lie flat on your back. Hand on chest, hand on belly. Breathe normally for one minute. Which hand moves more?

- ☐ Chest hand significantly more
- ☐ Chest hand slightly more
- ☐ About equal
- ☐ Belly hand slightly more
- ☐ Belly hand significantly more

Test 3 — Count test: How long is your natural inhale? Count: __ counts. How long is your natural exhale? Count: __ counts.

Is your exhale longer than your inhale? [Yes / No / Same]

Rate baseline breath signals (0 = none, 10 = constant):

Feel like I can't get a full breath [____]
Hold my breath without realizing [____]
Sigh repeatedly during the day [____]
Wake up with shallow breathing [____]
Catch myself "wired but tired" [____]
Hard to fall asleep due to racing mind [____]
Tense shoulders / neck without cause [____]

Three honest sentences about my breathing:

1.

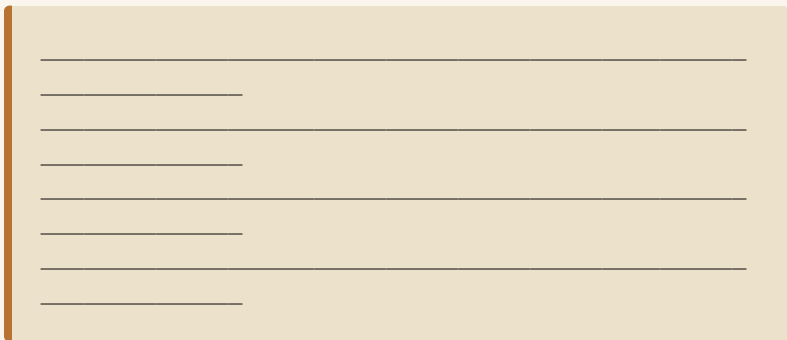
2.

3.

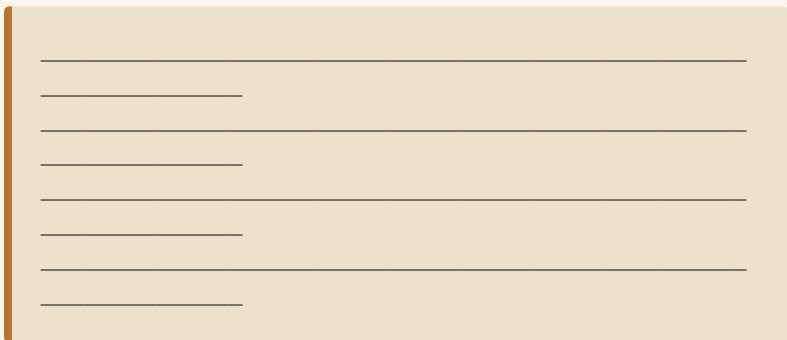
CHAPTER 3

Reflection Prompts

PROMPT 1: WHEN DURING YOUR DAY DO YOU tend to hold your breath without realizing? At what activity, around what people, in what context?



Prompt 2: What does your breath do when you're stressed? Stops? Speeds up? Goes shallow? Goes loud? Map your stress-breath signature.



Prompt 3: Try the 4-6 breath pattern for 30 seconds right now (inhale 4, exhale 6). What changed? What did your shoulders, jaw, or chest do during it?

CHAPTER 4

Pick Your Practice Method

LOCK THIS IN. THE PRACTICE DOESN'T WORK IF it doesn't happen.

Which method will I use?

- [] Method 1 — Anchor: 5 minutes during _____ (existing daily routine)
- [] Method 2 — Micro-doses: 10 breaths × _____ times throughout the day
- [] Method 3 — Paired with body scan: 5 breaths into each tension area found

Which breath pattern will I use?

- [] 4 in, 6 out (recommended starter)
- [] 4 in, 7 hold, 8 out (4-7-8 — best for sleep / deep relaxation)
- [] Custom: _ **in**, **hold (optional)**, _ out

When in the day will I do it? _____

Where? _____

CHAPTER 5

7-Day Breath Practice Tracker

FOR THE NEXT WEEK, TRACK YOUR DAILY practice and what you notice.

Daily check pattern

- Did I do the practice today? (Y/N)
 - How long? (minutes)
 - Where did I feel it most? (calmer chest, looser shoulders, dropped jaw, slower mind, etc.)
 - Energy / mood after (1-10)
-

Day 1 — Date: ____

Practice done? ☐ / **Duration:** ____ min / **Where I felt it:** ____

Energy after (1-10): [__]

Day 2 — Date: _____

Practice done? ☐ / **Duration:** ____ min / **Where I felt it:** ____

Energy after (1-10): [__]

Day 3 — Date: _____

Practice done? ☐ / **Duration:** ____ min / **Where I felt it:** ____

Energy after (1-10): [__]

Day 4 — Date: _____

Practice done? ☐ / **Duration:** ____ min / **Where I felt it:** ____

Energy after (1-10): [__]

Day 5 — Date: _____

Practice done? ☐ / **Duration:** ____ min / **Where I felt it:** ____

Energy after (1-10): [__]

Day 6 — Date: _____

Practice done? ☐ / Duration: _____ min / Where I felt it: _____

Energy after (1-10): [____]

Day 7 — Date: _____

Practice done? ☐ / Duration: _____ min / Where I felt it: _____

Energy after (1-10): [____]

CHAPTER 6

End-of-Week Reflection

REDO THE BREATH TESTS FROM THE BEGINNING.

Test 1 — Sitting watch: What moves now?

- ☐ Shoulders / ☐ Chest / ☐ Belly / ☐ Mixed
- Compared to Day 1: ☐ better / ☐ same

Test 2 — Lying watch: Which hand moves more now?

- ☐ Chest / ☐ Equal / ☐ Belly
- Compared to Day 1: ☐ better / ☐ same

Test 3 — Count test: Natural inhale: _ **counts**. Natural exhale: ___ counts.

- Compared to Day 1 (inhale: , **exhale:**): ☐ longer exhale now / ☐ same

Re-rate breath signals (0-10):

Can't get a full breath	[____]	(Day 1:
[____])		
Hold my breath without realizing	[____]	(Day 1:
[____])		
Sigh repeatedly	[____]	(Day 1:
[____])		
Wired but tired	[____]	(Day 1:
[____])		
Hard to fall asleep	[____]	(Day 1:
[____])		

What changed in 7 days?

Did I keep the daily practice? [Yes / Mostly / Sometimes / No]

What helped me remember to do it?

Recommitment for next week:

[illegible]

CHAPTER 7

Try this for 7 days

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS WORKBOOK, try this:

Ten slow breaths every night before bed. Inhale 4, exhale 6. For one week.

Just before you turn out the light. Doesn't have to be on the floor, doesn't have to be elaborate. Sitting on the edge of the bed works. Lying down works.

Ten breaths. Slow. Belly moves, shoulders don't.

Most people fall asleep faster within 4-5 nights. That's the whole experiment.

Bring this workbook to your next session.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
LMT and published by Healing Hands By
Nate.